Wenda Zhang

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EDUCATION

University of Chicago, IL, USA *08/2026-06/2027*

Master of Arts in Economics (Chair Scholar Award $10,000)

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, IL, USA *01/2024-05/2026*

Bachelor of Science in Econometrics and Quantitative Economics (with Distinction, GPA3.64/4.0, Dean's List, 2024)

Xi'an Jiaotong-Liverpool University, Suzhou, China

Economics and Finance (Transferred to UIUC; First-Class Standing, Top 10% in Department) *08/2022-01/2024*

WORKING PAPERS

Performance Measures and Local Government Behavior: Evidence from China's Wastewater Treatment Targets

with Yuhang Pan (Peking University) and Haotian Yu (Georgia Institute of Technology)

- Study how Chinese local governments responded to wastewater-treatment targets under the 11th Five-Year Plan, exploiting cross-city variation in the distance between pre-policy treatment rates and assigned targets in a two-sided continuous-treatment DiD design.
- Show that cities further below their targets increased treated wastewater volume, treatment capacity, and plant construction, but not sewer-network expansion. This pattern follows the structure of the assessed treatment-rate indicator: plants raise treated volume directly, while sewer expansion raises both treated and collected wastewater and therefore contributes less to the measured rate.
- Decompose the response into plant utilization and new capacity, finding that cities with spare capacity ran existing plants harder while capacity-constrained cities built new plants. Despite the large treatment expansion, river water quality, industrial firm behavior and water use, and domestic pollutant discharge show no comparable differential improvement.

When Treatment Intensity Is Built from the Baseline Outcome: Mechanical Convergence in Distance-to-Target Designs

with Yuhang Pan (Peking University) and Haotian Yu (Georgia Institute of Technology)

- Examine continuous treatment DiD designs where treatment intensity is constructed from the gap between a policy target and the baseline and derive the mechanical dose response generated by regression to the mean.
- Show that standard clipped codings amplify mechanical convergence, while signed-dose specifications eliminate target-specific variation; a two-sided spline isolates the target kink, which itself requires a no-policy benchmark.
- Develop placebo-target, placebo-date, untreated-unit, and base-year-relocation diagnostics and apply them to Chinese city data and six published studies. In several cases, placebo designs with no policy reproduce much of the estimated response, highlighting the need to distinguish policy effects from mechanically induced convergence.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Shadow Schooling Shutdown: The Effects of China's Double Reduction Policy on Household Expenditures and Consumption *03/2025-12/2025*

University of Illinois at Urbana Champaign | Undergraduate Thesis | Supervised by Prof. Riley League.

- Construct household- and child-level panel data from the 2020 and 2022 China Family Panel Studies and use a difference-in-differences design to study the effects of China's "Double Reduction" policy.
- Find that the reform reduced private tutoring and household education expenditures, with little evidence of changes in total consumption or average propensity to consume.

Historical U.S. Agricultural Credit and Agricultural Production Data Project *09/2024-05/2025*

University of Illinois at Urbana Champaign | Research Assistant | Supervised by Prof. Jared Hutchins.

- Constructed a historical U.S. database linking agricultural credit conditions to agricultural production outcomes to study the relationship between financial institutions and agricultural development.
- Digitized historical U.S. agricultural and financial archival records using optical character recognition (OCR) and conducted manual verification and structured data extraction.

Firm-Level Breakthrough Innovation in Contemporary Enterprises *08/2023-12/2023*

Xi'an Jiao tong-Liverpool University | Research Assistant | Supervised by Prof. Xiao Wang

- Assisted with data organization, variable construction, and preliminary empirical analysis of factors associated with breakthrough innovation. Conducted literature reviews and contributed to the development of the project's theoretical framework on firm-level breakthrough innovation.

AI Adoption in Accounting and Auditing: Textual Evidence on ESG Opportunities *08/2023-12/2023*

Xi'an Jiao tong-Liverpool University | Research Assistant | Supervised by Prof. Linhan Zhang

- Constructed a structured text corpus to examine discussions of AI-enabled audit quality and transparency

SELECTED COURSEWORK

Graduate Level: Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, Econometrics (*in progress*)

Mathematics: Probability Theory, Linear Algebra, Differential Equations, Advanced Calculus

Econometrics: Intermediate Econometrics, Advanced Economic Statistics, Financial Econometrics, Forecasting

Economics: Public Economics, Behavioral Economics, International Trade

SKILLS & TESTS

Programming and Statistical Software: Stata (proficient), R (proficient), Python (proficient)

Other Tools: Matlab, Latex, Java, Excel (advanced)

Test: Graduate Record Examinations (GRE): Verbal: 160 | Quantitative: 170 | Analytical Writing: 4.0 | Oct 2025

LEADERSHIP & ACTIVITIES

Xi'an Jiao tong-Liverpool University Law Society, **President & Head of Academic Affairs** *12/2022-12/2023*

- Provided legal assistance to students across the university, including supporting litigation that helped students who had been defrauded recover financial losses; Organized recurring law forums and academic seminars, coordinating speakers, event logistics, and student participation.